PassFrame
TUITION

Mary Anning: Fossil Hunter

Year 4 — 11+ Lesson Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (Biography)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

Mary Anning was born in 1799 in the small seaside town of Lyme Regis, England — a place famous even then for the strange, stony shapes that washed out of its crumbling cliffs after every storm. Her family was poor, and from a young age Mary helped collect and sell these curiosities to earn money.

What nobody realised at first was that these “curiosities” were actually fossils — the remains of creatures that had lived millions of years earlier, long before any human walked the Earth. Mary had an extraordinary talent for spotting fossils that others walked straight past.

When Mary was just twelve years old, she made a discovery that would change the course of science: the complete skeleton of an ichthyosaur, a huge sea creature with a long snout and enormous eyes, unlike anything scientists had ever properly studied before.

Despite her remarkable discoveries, Mary faced great difficulty being taken seriously. Women were not allowed to join the Geological Society at the time, and many of the male scientists who bought her fossils took the credit for finding them, rarely mentioning her name in their published work.

Today, however, Mary Anning is recognised as one of the most important fossil hunters in history. Her discoveries helped shape our early understanding of prehistoric life, and scientists still study specimens she found over two hundred years ago.

Questions

20 min · 12 questions

1. In which town was Mary Anning born, and in which year?

2. What did Mary's family do to earn money when she was young?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you what the “curiosities” washed out of the cliffs actually were.

4. Underline the sentence that describes Mary's major discovery at age twelve.

5. What does “extraordinary” suggest about Mary's ability to find fossils?

6. True or false: Mary was allowed to join the Geological Society.

7. Why do you think many male scientists took credit for Mary's discoveries instead of crediting her?

8. What creature's skeleton did Mary discover when she was twelve?

9. In your own words, explain why Mary's work was so important to science.

10. What does the final paragraph suggest about how Mary is viewed today, compared to during her lifetime?

11. Why do you think the author chose to describe the ichthyosaur's snout and eyes in detail?

12. Do you think it was fair that Mary rarely received credit during her lifetime? Explain your answer.